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People's Resistance Against the British

INTRODUCTION

The British expansion in India faced widespread resistance from various social groups, including **peasants**, **artisans**, **tribals**, **military personnel**, and **ruling classes**. This resistance unfolded in multiple forms—**civil rebellions**, **tribal uprisings**, **peasant revolts**, and **military mutinies**—both before and after 1857.

IMPORTANT CIVIL REBELLIONS AT A GLANCE

Name & Year (Region)	Description
Sanyasi Revolt (1763-1800, Bengal & Bihar)	Leaders: Majnum Shah, Chirag Ali, Musa Shah, Bhawani Pathak, Debi Chaudharani. Causes: The 1770 Bengal famine, high revenue demands by British officials, dispossession of zamindars, and widespread exploitation. Both Hindu and Muslim sanyasis united against British oppression. Response: Suppressed by military action under Warren Hastings. Significance: Inspired by Bankim Chandra Chatterjee's <i>Anandamath</i>, with the patriotic anthem "Vande Mataram."
Moamarias Revolt (1769-1799, Assam)	Leader: Aniruddhadeva. Causes: Discontent with the Ahom kingdom's policies, British interference destabilised the region. Response: British assisted Ahoms in suppressing the revolt but failed to prevent the later Burmese invasion. Outcome: The Ahom kingdom weakened, eventually leading to British annexation of Assam.
Civil Uprisings in Gorakhpur, Basti (1781, Uttar Pradesh)	Leaders: Zamindars, cultivators, with complaints against British agent Alexander Hannay. Cause: Excessive revenue demands imposed by Hannay. Response: British military intervention led to Hannay's dismissal and the end of the Izara system. Outcome: Zamindars regained control, exposing the flaws of British revenue farming.
Midnapore and Dhalbhum Revolt (1766-74, Bengal)	Leaders: Damodar Singh, Jagannath Dhal. Cause: Resentment against the new revenue system imposed by the British. Response: Suppressed by British forces. Outcome: The revolt consolidated British control, further marginalising local zamindars.
Poligars' Revolt (1795-1805, Tamil Nadu)	Leaders: Kattaboman Nayakan, Oomanthurai. Cause: British revenue policies and loss of autonomy by local chieftains or Poligars. Response: Revolt was suppressed, with Kattaboman executed. Outcome: Kattaboman became a regional hero symbolising resistance against British policies.
Ganjam and Gumsur Uprising (1800, 1835-37, Orissa)	Leaders: Local zamindars and peasants. Cause: Oppressive taxation and harsh revenue policies. Response: British suppression. Outcome: Established British authority in Ganjam and Gumsur.

Palamau Uprisings (1800-02, Jharkhand)	Leaders: Tribal chieftains and peasants Bhukhan Singh. Cause: Exploitation through revenue collection and loss of tribal autonomy. Response: Suppression by British forces. Outcome: British strengthened control over Chhotanagpur and weakened tribal resistance.
Kerala Varma Pazhassi Raja Revolt (1797-1805, Kerala)	Leader: Kerala Varma Pazhassi Raja, supported by Nairs, Mappilas, and Pathans. Cause: Discontent with British tax policies and Wayanad dispute. Response: British suppression with Pazhassi Raja's eventual death. Significance: Symbol of resistance in Kerala and legacy of local resistance against British imperialism.
Vizianagaram Rebellion (1794, Andhra Pradesh)	Leader: Raja of Vizianagaram. Cause: British revenue demands, loss of autonomy, and broken promises by the British. Response: Raja was killed; British later reconciled with his son. Outcome: Vizianagaram was brought under direct British influence.
Awadh Civil Rebellion (1799, Eastern UP)	Leaders: Zamindars and peasants. Cause: British interference in Awadh's traditional administrative setup. Response: Suppressed by British military. Outcome: Awadh's local control diminished under British influence.
Haryana Uprisings (Bhiwani) (1803 onwards)	Leaders: Local chieftains and peasants. Cause: Cession of Haryana to the British following the Treaty of Surji-Arjungaon. Response: Suppressed by British forces. Outcome: Haryana integrated into British India, establishing British administration.
Vellore Mutiny (1806, Tamil Nadu)	Leaders: Indian sepoys. Cause: British military dress code perceived as religious insult, banning traditional attire. Response: Mutiny suppressed; British withdrew the dress code. Outcome: Led to sensitivity in British policies regarding Indian religious practices.
Bundelkhand Disturbances (1808-12)	Leaders: Local chieftains and peasants. Cause: Resentment over contractual obligations (Ikarnamahs) imposed by the British. Response: Suppression by British forces. Outcome: Consolidated British power in Bundelkhand.
Dewan Velu Thambi Revolt (1808-1809, Travancore)	Leader: Dewan Velu Thambi, supported by Nair troops. Cause: Objections to British subsidiary alliance and tax burdens. Response: Suppression led to Thambi's death. Outcome: Marked a significant local resistance, and British dominance in Travancore was reaffirmed.
Parlakimedi Uprising (1813-34, Odisha)	Leaders: Local tribal leaders and zamindars. (Narayan Deo and Gajpati Deo) Cause: Excessive land and revenue taxes. Response: Suppression, administrative adjustments by British. Outcome: Parlakimedi formally integrated into British control.

Bareilly Rising (1816, Uttar Pradesh)	Leaders: Zamindars and peasants (Mufti Muhammad Aiwaz). Cause: Discontent with British-imposed police tax. Response: Suppression, with leaders captured or executed. Outcome: Highlighted widespread discontent against colonial taxation policies.
Paika Rebellion (1817, Odisha)	Leader: Bakshi Jagabandhu Bidyadhar. Cause: Forced land dispossession, revenue demands, currency devaluation. Response: Suppression with leaders arrested or executed. Outcome: Demonstrated early anti-British sentiment; later led to minor tax and land reforms in the region.
Kutch Rebellion (1816-1832, Gujarat)	Leader: Maharaja Bharamal II. Cause: British interference in Kutch's administration. Response: Military action followed by reconciliation. Outcome: British influence limited, with some autonomy preserved for Kutch rulers.
Waghera Rising (1818-1820, Gujarat)	Leader: Waghera chieftains. Cause: Dispute over Baroda's fortification. Response: Ended with a peace treaty. Outcome: Set a precedent for negotiated solutions to conflicts involving local rulers.
Wahabi Movement (1830-1861, Bengal, Bihar, NWFP, Punjab)	Leaders: Syed Ahmed, Titu Mir. Cause: Islamic revivalism with anti-British objectives. Response: Military suppression of Wahabi cells. Outcome: Spread anti-colonial ideology, influencing future freedom movements.
Satara Revolt (1840, Maharashtra)	Leaders: Dhar Rao Pawar, Narasingh Petkar. Cause: Deposition of Chhatrapati Pratapsingh by the British. Response: Suppression by British. Outcome: Fuelled Maratha resentment and resistance against British policies.
Gadkari Revolt (1844, Maharashtra)	Leaders: Gadkari community. Cause: Loss of land, privileges under British revenue policies. Response: Suppressed by the British. Outcome: Extended British control over Marathas; showcased the resistance of traditional classes.

TRIBAL REVOLTS AT A GLANCE

The most common factor for tribal movements was the complete disruption of the old agrarian order of the tribal communities.
[UPSC 2011]

First Phase (1795 - 1860)	
Leader(s) & Year & Region	Reason(s) & Features/Developments
Pahariya Rebellion (1778, Rajmahal Hills) Leader: Raja Jagannath	Resistance to British-imposed settled agriculture. Disruption of traditional raiding practices and tribute collection. British intervention and concessions to local chiefs.
Revolt of Tilka Manjhi (1778-1785, Santhal Pargana) Leader: Tilka Manjhi (Jabra Paharia)	Opposed British efforts to undermine tribal traditions. Tilka Manjhi led guerrilla attacks, looting the British treasury. Defeated in 1785; symbolised resistance against colonial rule.

Chuar Uprising (1766-72, 1795-1816) Jungle Mahal Rebellion, Bengal) Leaders: Durjan Singh, Madhab Singh, Raja Mohan Singh, Lachman Singh, Jagannath Singh	Caused by increased taxes and the Permanent Settlement. Local tribals like the Chuar resisted British economic control. Rebellions across Bankura, Midnapore, and Manbhum. Suppressed by British forces.
Tamar Revolts (Oraon and Munda, 1798; 1914-15, Tamar, Chhotanagpur) Leaders: Bholanath Sahay (1798-1832); Jatra Bhagat, Balram Bhagat (1914-15)	Caused by economic exploitation of tribals, loss of tribal lands to landlords and moneylenders and interference and undermining of tribal cultural practices. The revolt was marked by violent clashes between the Mundas and British forces. The Tamar region became a center of resistance, with tribal warriors attacking revenue officials, zamindars, and police posts. The British crushed the revolt with military force, arresting and executing key leaders.
Bhil Uprising (1817-19, Western Ghats, Khandesh, South Rajasthan) Leader: Govind Guru (1913 Mangarh Massacre)	Bhils resisted British control over mountain routes and tribute systems. Grievances over economic hardship from colonial policies. Rebellions spread across Gujarat, Maharashtra, and Madhya Pradesh. Suppressed by British forces.
Ramosi Uprising (1822–1829, Western Ghats, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh) Leaders: Chittur Singh, Umaji Naik, Bapu Trimbakji Sawant	Former Maratha soldiers led revolts after the loss of power post-Maratha defeat. Resistance to British annexation of Satara. Rebellions in Western Ghats and Maharashtra. British forces eventually quelled the uprisings.
Ahom Revolt (1828-1833, Assam) Leaders: Gomadhar Konwar, Dhanjay Borgohain, Jairam Khargharia Phukan	British violations of the Treaty of Yandaboo (1826) led to resistance. Ahom nobility opposed British annexation and interference. Uprisings aimed at regaining sovereignty. Suppressed by the British military.
Kol Mutiny (1831-32, Chotanagpur region) Leader: Buddho Bhagat	Resistance to British revenue policies and exploitation. Grievances centred on land rights and British interference. Rebellions ultimately suppressed by British forces.
Santhal Rebellion (1855-56, Rajmahal Hills) Leaders: Sidhu Murmu, Kanhu Murmu	Resistance to British land revenue policies and exploitation by zamindars. Initial successes in capturing territory. Suppressed by British forces but marked as a symbol of tribal resistance.
Khond Uprising (1837-56, Orissa, Andhra Pradesh) Leader: Chakra Bisoi	Opposition to British efforts to abolish tribal customs. Resistance to British intrusion in local governance and social practices. Guerrilla warfare tactics used. Subdued by the British but important in highlighting tribal discontent.
Koli Uprising (1822-29, Maharashtra; 1857, Gujarat) Leaders: Ramji Bhangre (1822-29), Maganlal Bhukhan, Dwarakadas, Jetha Madhavji (1857)	Grievances over taxation, land loss, and British economic control. Uprisings in Maharashtra and Gujarat, including during the 1857 revolt. Crushed by British military forces but indicated widespread colonial discontent.

Second Phase (1860-1920)

Leader(s) & Year	Reason(s), Features, and Impact
Ho and Munda Revolt (1820-37; 1890s, Singhbhum & Ranchi, Chotanagpur region) Leader: Raja of Parahat (Ho), Birsa Munda	In 1765, Chotanagpur came under British control as part of Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa. The Raja of Singhbhum initially sought protection from the British in 1767 but acknowledged British feudal control in 1820. The Hos, initially allied with the British, eventually broke their alliance and united with the Mundas, leading to the Kol Uprising (1831-33). The rebellion targeted dikkus (non-Adivasi landowners) through violence, including the burning of houses and significant casualties. The British land policies undermined the traditional system, such as the Khuntkatti system (joint tenures), and missionary activities undermined their traditional culture. The exploitation of land by moneylenders intensified their suffering. Birsa Munda (1890s) became a prominent leader, promoting social reforms like abstinence from alcohol and witchcraft, cleanliness, and social reforms. Led armed rebellion against British authorities with a goal to liberate tribal communities from British oppression and exploitation. Impact: The Ulgulan movement severely shook British rule in the region. The Chotanagpur Tenancy Act (1908) was enacted to protect tribal rights. Legacy: Birsa Munda is revered as a tribal hero and a symbol of resistance against colonial oppression.
Naikada Movement (1860s, Madhya Pradesh & Gujarat) Leader: Unspecified	Revolt against British authority and upper-caste Hindus . Tribal areas resisted the increasing dominance of British and upper-caste interests. Focused on challenging the colonial and caste oppression in these regions.
Kharwar Rebellion (1870s, Bihar) Leader: Unspecified	The Kharwar tribes revolted to assert their traditional rights and resist British revenue policies. Focused on opposition to the British revenue settlement activities.
Bhuyan and Juang Rebellions (Late 19th to early 20th century, Odisha) Leader: Ratna Nayak, Dharni Dhar Nayak	Resistance against British-imposed forest policies. The Bhuyan and Juang tribes resisted British encroachment and restrictive policies on tribal forests.
Bokta Rising (1858-1895, Chotanagpur) Leader: Unspecified	Extended period of revolts by the Bokta community against British policies and land exploitation. The community fought for land rights and against colonial policies.
Koya Rebellion (1879-80, Eastern Godavari tract of Andhra Pradesh and Malkangiri region in Odisha) Leader: Tomma Dora	Erosion of customary rights over forests, heavy taxes on timber and grazing, police exactions, and exploitations by moneylenders, along with new excise regulations on toddy production. Tomma Dora led a major revolt in 1880, seizing a police station, defeating a British contingent, and gaining the title of “King” of Malkangiri. Following Tomma Dora’s demise, Raja Anantayyar organised another revolt in 1886.
Khonda Dora Campaign (1900, Dabur Region, Visakhapatnam) Leader: Korra Mallaya	Korra Mallaya organised the Khonda Doras to oppose British incursions in the region. Led mobilisation efforts to protect local resources, autonomy, and resist British exploitation.
Bastar Revolt (1910, Jagdalpur) Leader: Unspecified	A significant tribal uprising against feudal exploitation and forest levies. Tribes protested colonial exploitation and feudal structures that infringed on tribal land rights.

Tana Bhagat Movement (1914-1920, Oraon tribes, Chotanagpur, Jharkhand) Leaders: Jatra Bhagat/Balram bhagat	Economic exploitation by landlords, moneylenders, and the British. Swaraj (freedom) signified liberation from British oppression and local exploitation. Focused on eradicating social practices like the worship of ghosts, spirits, and exorcism. Influenced by Mahatma Gandhi's non-violence and satyagraha philosophy. Jatra Bhagat, claiming divine ordination, led the movement, which started in 1914. The movement used non-violent methods such as satyagraha, influencing resistance before Gandhi's Non-Cooperation Movement. The movement became a significant part of tribal resistance. In 1921, the Tana Bhagats allied with Congress, strengthening the wider independence struggle.
Third Phase (1920-1947)	
Leader(s) & Year	Reason(s), Features, and Impact
Rampa Rebellion (Manyam Rebellion) (1922-1924, Koyas of Godavari Agency, Andhra Pradesh) Leader: Alluri Sitarama Raju	The revolt was a response to British imposition of forced labour, restrictions on gathering minor forest produce, and prohibition of traditional agricultural practices. In August 1922, Alluri Sitarama Raju led a three-day assault on police stations in Godavari Agency, successfully seizing 26 carbine rifles and 2,500 rounds of ammunition. Raju mobilised the Adivasis against British police, forest, and revenue officials. Raju's efforts were centred on resisting the Madras Forest Act of 1882, asserting the tribal rights to forest produce. His leadership inspired a fierce rebellion and significant tribal mobilisation against the British in the region. Legacy: His resistance continued until his capture and execution in 1924, cementing his role as a martyr in the fight against British colonial rule.
Chenchu Tribal Movement (1921-1922, Nallamalai Forests, Andhra Pradesh) Leaders: Venkattappaya, K. Hanumanthu	The movement was driven by tribal opposition to British control over forests. Venkattappaya and K. Hanumanthu connected with Gandhi's Non-Cooperation Movement, leading to forest satyagraha. The Chenchus engaged in non-violent resistance, allowing their cattle to graze freely in the forest in defiance of British fees. The movement spread to Palnad, where the people declared Swaraj and confronted the police. This was part of the larger tribal response to British impositions during the 1920s, aligning with broader nationalist movements. The movement showcased tribal resistance and their role in the Indian independence struggle.
Rani Gaidinliu's Naga Movement (1930s, Zeliangrong Territory, Manipur) Leader: Rani Gaidinliu	The Heraka movement, led by Haipou Jadonang, was a socio-religious movement advocating for Naga self-(Naga Raj) and resistance against British missionaries and their efforts to convert the tribes to Christianity. Rani Gaidinliu, after embracing Gandhian principles, initiated an open rebellion against British rule at the age of 17. The Naga tribes refused to pay taxes and cooperate with the British. The movement had reformist religious objectives but also strong political undertones challenging British rule. The British authorities, fearful of the movement's growing influence, arrested and executed Jadonang in 1931. Gaidinliu was captured in 1932 and sentenced to life imprisonment. Despite repression, the movement had lasting cultural and political impacts on Naga resistance.
Gond Uprising (1940s) Leader: Unspecified	The Gond Uprising was focused on uniting the followers of Gond Dharma against British rule. The movement emphasised tribal unity and religious identity as tools to oppose British oppression. The uprising was part of the broader tribal resistance in central India against colonial authority.

Movements in North-East	
Tribal Revolt/Uprising (Year, Region, Leader(s))	Reason(s) & Features/Developments
Khasi Uprising (up to 1833, Garo & Jaintia Hills, Meghalaya – Tirath Singh)	Resistance against the entry of outsiders, including Englishmen and Bengali labourers. Widespread but ultimately suppressed by 1833, involving multiple hill tribes like Khasis, Garos, Khamptis, and Singphos.
Singphos Rebellion (1830 onwards, Assam – Nirang Phidu)	Resentment towards British control, targeting British officials. Notable rebellion in 1839, leading to the death of a British political agent. Another significant revolt in 1843 with an attack on a British garrison.
Kukis Revolt (1917-1919, Manipur)	Opposition to British labour recruitment policies during World War I. Widespread revolt as Kukis resisted the exploitation of their people for war-related labour.
Zeliangsong Movement (1920s, Manipur – Zemi, Liangmei, Rongmei tribes)	Reaction to British failure to protect them during the Kuki revolt. A tribal alliance emphasising unity and rights among the Zemi, Liangmei, and Rongmei tribes.
Naga Movement (1905-1931, Manipur – Jadonang)	Aimed at establishing an independent 'Naga Raj.' Led the Nagas against British authority, promoting political autonomy and cultural preservation.
Synteng Rebellion (1860-62, Jaintia Hills)	Resistance against British interference in the Jaintia Hills. Tribes of Jaintia Hills mounted armed resistance against colonial policies.
Phulaguri Peasant Rebellion (1861, Assam)	Revolt against exploitative British policies. One of the early anti-British peasant uprisings in Assam.
Revolt of the Saflas (1872-73, Assam)	Uprising against British-imposed forest and revenue policies. The Safla community organised resistance against British control.
Kacha Naga Uprising (1882, Cachhar)	Protested against colonial exploitation and encroachment into tribal lands. Demonstrated the determination of the Kacha Nagas to protect their land rights.
Khampti Rebellion (1839-1842, Assam)	Resistance against British dominance and disruption of local governance. Fierce uprisings against British officials in Assam.
Lushais Revolt (1842-1844, Manipur)	Reaction to British alliances and exploitation. Marked by multiple attacks on British-allied villages, reflecting tribal discontent.

MILITARY UPRISINGS BEFORE 1857

Military uprisings before 1857 laid the groundwork for the **Indian Rebellion of 1857** by revealing deep-seated discontent among Indian soldiers, or sepoys, due to various grievances. Although localised, these revolts foreshadowed the larger rebellion and highlighted the sepoys' dissatisfaction with British policies and practices.

Causes

- **Discrimination:** Sepoys faced **unequal pay** and **limited promotions** compared to British soldiers.
- **Mistreatment:** Frequent **abuse** by British officials fueled resentment.
- **Foreign Service Allowance Denial:** Sepoys were not compensated when sent to distant postings.
- **Religious Concerns:**
 - **General Service Enlistment Act (1856):** Required sepoys to serve overseas, conflicting with **high-caste Hindus'** religious beliefs.
 - Other instances, like the **replacement of the turban** with a leather cockade (1806) or orders to cross the sea, leading to **loss of caste**.
- **Alignment with Civilian Grievances:** Sepoys shared the **social, religious, and economic discontent** affecting the wider Indian population.

Major Pre-1857 Mutinies

- **Bengal Sepoy Mutiny (1764):** Early signs of sepoy unrest.
- **Vellore Mutiny (1806):** Revolt in response to interference with **social and religious practices**; rebels raised the Mysore flag.
- **47th Native Infantry Mutiny (1824):** Occurred over forced deployment.
- **Grenadier Company Revolt (1825, Assam)** and **Sholapur Mutiny (1838).**
- **Mutinies of the 34th, 22nd, 66th, and 37th Native Infantry (1844–1852):** Sporadic revolts across different regiments.

PEASANT MOVEMENTS

During the pre-independence period, **peasant movements** in India surged due to economic hardships and political awareness, focusing on **tenancy rights**, **fair rents**, and **debt relief**.

- **Factors Leading to Peasant Movements in Colonial India**
 - **Stagnation of Agriculture:** No investment in agriculture, neglected irrigation, lack of modern techniques → Low productivity.
 - **Land Revenue Policies:**
 - ◆ **Zamindari (1793)** - High fixed revenue; exploited peasants.
 - ◆ **Mahalwari (1819)** - Village-based revenue; community responsibility.
 - ◆ **Ryotwari (1820)** - Direct peasant-government link; high rent.

- **Commercialization of Agriculture:** Shift to cash crops (cotton, jute) → Food insecurity, landless labourers, uneven benefits.
- **Indebtedness:** Heavy taxes → Forced loans from moneylenders at high interest → Land loss, tenant status.
- **Famines:** Recurrent famines and economic depression → Uprisings.
- **Social Inequality:** Caste-based discrimination; exploitation of lower castes.
- **Rise of INC & Charismatic Leaders:** INC, leaders (Gandhi, Gaidinliu, Birsu Munda) inspired peasant mobilisation.
- **Emergence of Organizations:** From 1922 to 1927, several organisations formed to support peasants and workers, including **Labour Swaraj Party** (Bengal), **Congress Labour Party** (Bombay), **Kirti Kisan Party** (Punjab) & **Labour Kisan Party of Hindustan** (Madras). This era also saw around **200 strikes** in the early 1920s, with journals like **Gana Vaani** and **Mehnatkash** mobilising support.

IMPORTANT PEASANT MOVEMENTS

First Phase: Peasant Movements Before 1857

Movement Year & Region Leader(s)	Causes and Consequences
Sanyasi Revolt 1763-1800, Bengal Leaders: Maznoon Shah; Bhawani Pathak, Devi Choudhurani	Cause: British restrictions on pilgrimages to sacred Hindu and Muslim sites. The Bengal Famine of 1770 sparked widespread discontent. Participants: Landless peasants, displaced zamindars, disbanded soldiers, impoverished masses. Active involvement of Sanyasis and Fakirs. Character: Attacks on British factories, seizing goods, cash, arms, ammunition. Unified resistance with Hindu and Muslim monks against British rule. British Response: Led by Warren Hastings. Cultural Impact: Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay's novel <i>Anandmath</i> captured the revolt's essence.
Narkelberia Uprising 1782-1831, West Bengal Leaders: Mir Nithar Ali (Titu Mir)	Cause: Muslim tenants' resistance against Hindu landlords imposing a beard tax on Faraizis. Opposition to British Indigo planters. Nature: Armed uprising, considered the first peasant revolt against the British. Evolution: Transformed into a religious conflict, merging with the Wahabi Movement. The Wahabi Movement had broader religious and socio-political aims.
Pagal Panthis (of Hajong and Garo tribes) 1825-1833 , Mymensingh, earlier in Bengal Leaders: Karam Shah and Tipu Shah	Cause: Resistance against zamindar oppression and unjust rent claims. Movement aimed at shielding peasants from exploitation by zamindars. Nature: Semi-religious peasant uprising led by religious mendicants, the Pagal Panthis. Outcome: The government responded with a rent reduction and other concessions. The movement divided, leading to a return of peace. Tipu Shah and insurgents were apprehended and tried by the British.

Second Phase: Peasant Movements After 1857

Indigo Revolt 1859-60; Nadia, Bengal [UPSC 2020] Leaders: Bishnucaharan Biswas and Digambar Biswas (Biswas brothers) of Nadia, Rafique Mondal of Malda and Kader Molla of Pabna	Cause: Peasant resistance against coerced indigo cultivation for European planters. Exploitation through fraudulent contracts, coercion, and threats. Nature: Peasants attacked indigo factories with spears and swords. Physical and economic resistance, including rent strikes. Significant in Pabna district. Outcome: British response: Indigo Commission (1860) to address abuses. Victory for peasants, as indigo cultivation declined by 1860. Cultural Impact: <i>Neel Darpan</i> (1860) by Dinabandhu Mitra, and articles in <i>The Hindu Patriot</i> by Harish Chandra Mukherjee raised awareness of the peasants' plight. Indigo cultivation in India declined by the beginning of the 20th century because of its unprofitability in the world market because of new inventions. [UPSC 2020]
Deccan Peasants' Uprising 1875; Poona, Satara and Ahmednagar Leaders: Maratha Peasants	Cause: Ryotwari system's exploitation of peasants, favouring moneylenders (Vanis) over cultivators (Kunbis). High taxation, increased land revenue, and economic hardships (e.g., cotton price collapse, poor harvests). Peasants' resistance to oppressive debt contracts and mortgage bonds. Nature: Social boycott of moneylenders, particularly Marwari and Gujarati outsiders. Violent attacks on moneylenders' homes and shops; destruction of debt bonds. Spread across Poona, Ahmednagar, Sholapur, and Satara. Outcome: Government repression and eventual passing of the Deccan Agriculturists Relief Act (1879) to protect peasants. Support from Maharashtra's intelligentsia for the peasant cause.
Pabna Movement 1873-1885; Pabna, East Bengal (Bangladesh) Leaders: Shah Chandra Roy, Shambhu Nath Pal, Khodi Mollah;	Cause: Illegal property seizure, arbitrary rent hikes, and coercive eviction tactics by zamindars. Exploitation of tenants despite Act X of 1859, which granted immunity from eviction. Oppression through forcible evictions, crop seizures, and prolonged litigation. Nature: Formation of Agrarian League (1873) in Yusufshahi Pargana, aimed at organising rent strikes, raising funds for legal battles, and holding mass meetings. Armed resistance and legal challenges against oppressive zamindar practices. Outcome: Government military suppression of the movement. Bengal Tenancy Act (1885) passed, offering legislative protection for tenants. Intellectual support from figures like Bankim Chandra Chatterjee, R.C. Dutt, and the Indian Association under Surendra Nath Banerjee.
Ramosi Uprising 1877-87; Maharashtra Leaders: Vasudev Balwant Phadke	Cause: Protest against the British government's oppressive land tax policies and neglect during the Deccan famine of 1776-1777. Peasants faced severe hardship, and Phadke aimed to alleviate their suffering. Nature: Phadke, lacking funds, turned to raiding government treasuries to create an army and support the villagers. The first raid occurred in Dhamari (Pune district) targeting income tax stored in a home. Treasury raids occurred in Shirur and Khed talukas to support starving communities. Phadke strategically disabled British communication lines during his raids. Outcome: The uprising weakened when British forces ambushed and fatally shot Naik, a leader of the movement.
Punjab Peasants' Revolt Last decade of 19th Century; Punjab Leaders: Unspecified	Cause: Punjab Land Alienation Act (1900) aimed to restrict land ownership transfers, especially targeting the alienation of land from peasants to non-agricultural classes. The Act imposed a 15-year limit on land transactions, prohibiting urban professionals and traders from buying land from peasants.

Champaran Satyagraha 1917; Champaran, Bihar Leaders: Mahatma Gandhi, J.B. Kripalani, Babu Brajkishore Prasad and Babu Rajendra Prasad	Cause: The ‘Teen Kathia’ system forced tenant farmers to cultivate indigo on three-twentieths of a bigha of their land for British planters, leading to severe financial losses for peasants. Peasants had the option to endure the system or pay higher rents to abandon indigo cultivation. Nature: Gandhi initiated satyagraha (peaceful civil disobedience) against exploitation. Outcome: The government responded by inviting Gandhi for talks and appointing him to a committee. The committee’s findings led to the abolition of the Teen Kathia system.
Kheda Satyagraha 1918; Kheda, Gujarat Leaders: Mahatma Gandhi Leaders me add karo : Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, Mohanlal Pandya	Cause: Poor harvests in 1917-18 and rising prices of essential goods worsened the economic strain on peasants. Revenue remission demands were ignored by the colonial government. Nature: Gandhi decided to initiate Satyagraha after the government failed to address peasants’ demands. Local leaders like Mohanlal Kameshwar Pandya were arrested for defying government orders. Outcome: The government responded by instructing restraint in revenue collection and refraining from land confiscation. The movement successfully led to some relief for the peasants, recognizing the need for Indian support during British war efforts.
The Kisan Sabha Movement (1918–1921)	Background: After the 1857 revolt, Awadh taluqdars regained control and imposed high rents and oppressive practices. The Home Rule Movement and activists like Gauri Shankar Mishra and Indra Narayan Dwivedi led the formation of Kisan Sabhas in Uttar Pradesh. Nature: The United Provinces Kisan Sabha was established in February 1918, with support from Madan Mohan Malaviya. By June 1919, the Sabha had expanded to 450 branches. Awadh Kisan Sabha (1920): The movement urged peasants to refuse till bedakhali land, not to offer unpaid labour, and to resolve disputes through panchayats. Repression by the government led to the decline of the movement, and the Awadh Rent (Amendment) Act further contributed to its end.
Eka Movement 1921; Awadh, Uttar Pradesh Leaders: Madari Pasi and Baba Ramchandra	Cause: Economic distress caused by high rents, forced labour, and corruption by intermediaries like thekedars. The movement was sparked by drought, food shortages, and the effects of the Spanish flu. Nature: Initially aligned with Congress and Khilafat campaigns, the movement followed Gandhian principles of social boycotts, picketing, and peaceful protests. As the movement became more militant, Congress and Khilafat leaders distanced themselves, and it became independent. Outcome: Repression by authorities led to the movement’s collapse by March 1922.
Mappila Uprising 1921; Malabar region, Kerala Leaders: Mappila tenants (no specific leader noted)	Cause: Oppression by upper-caste Hindu landlords and British land laws in the 19th century, stripping Mappilas of customary land rights. Peasants were subjected to high rents, oppressive fees, and insecure tenures. The Khilafat movement and Congress support for tenants’ grievances laid the groundwork for the revolt. Nature: Initially focused on anti-government and anti-landlord sentiments, the rebellion evolved into a communal conflict. Following the arrest of key leaders like Ali Musaliar, the movement turned increasingly violent, with Hindus targeted due to their perceived support of the authorities. Outcome: The British imposed martial law and created the Malabar Special Police to suppress the rebellion. By December 1921, the movement ended, marked by its communal turn and repression, signalling the collapse of Mappila resistance.
Bardoli Satyagraha 1928; Surat, Gujarat	Cause: Peasant protest against a 30% tax hike imposed by the Bombay Presidency amidst famine and flood. Key Demands: Appointment of an independent tribunal for a fresh assessment of taxes. Acceptance of the previous tax amount as full payment.

Leaders: Vallabhbhai Patel, Chunnilal Mehta and Mehta brothers	Key Events: January 1926: Authorities proposed a 30% increase in land revenue, leading to farmer unrest. February 1926: Vallabhbhai Patel took charge, earning the title “Sardar” from Bardoli women. Peasant Mobilisation: Formation of the Bardoli Inquiry Committee, publication of the Bardoli Satyagraha Patrika, establishment of worker’s camps, and social boycotts of opponents. Women’s Role: Significant involvement in the movement, using bhajan mandalis, holy imagery, and communication with Adivasis. Political Support: K.M. Munshi and Lalji Naranji resigned from the Bombay Legislative Council in solidarity. Outcome: By June 1928, the British government reached a settlement mediated by Chunnilal Mehta. The government formed a committee, which recommended a smaller tax increase of 6.03%.
All India Kisan Sabha 1936, Formed at Lucknow Session of Indian National Congress (INC) Leaders: Swami Sahajananda Saraswati [UPSC 2019]	Cause: Formation of Kisan Sabhas to protect tenants’ rights and advocate for the abolition of zamindari. Key Events: 1936: The All India Kisan Sabha was established to address the plight of peasants. Manifesto: Called for the abolition of zamindari and the recognition of tenants’ occupancy rights. Impact: Kisan Sabha organised nationwide movements and led to key agrarian reforms after the 1937 elections, such as fixing interest rates, reducing rent increases, granting tenant status in UP, and restoring bakht lands in Bihar.
Bakasht Movement 1936, Bihar Leaders: Swami Sahajananda Saraswati	Cause: Resistance against the forced displacement of tenants from Bakasht lands (lands previously settled by peasants), and against oppressive landlords. Key Events: The movement gained widespread support across Bihar. 1938: Resolution passed by the Bihar Provincial Kisan Sabha at its annual conference in Waini to protest against zamindars. Impact: The Bihar Tenancy Act and Bakasht Land Tax were enacted to address these issues.
Tebhaga Movement 1946–47, Bengal Leaders: Poor peasants and tenants and bargadars or share-croppers (Bengal) [UPSC 2013]	Cause: Sharecroppers’ demand for a fair redistribution of the harvest, seeking a two-thirds share for themselves and one-third for landlords. [UPSC 2013] Key Participants: Poor peasants, bargadars (sharecroppers), and peasants’ organisations. Key Events: 1946: The Bengal Provincial Kisan Sabha advocated for the implementation of Tebhaga on the basis of the Flood Commission report. Slogan: “Nij khamare dhan tolo” (Take your produce to your own threshing floor). Support Base: The movement gained widespread participation, especially among Rajbanshis (a low-caste tribal group) and Muslims in Bengal. Outcome: 40% of peasants gained the two-thirds share; however, the movement faced repression and limited success in East Bengal.
Telangana Insurrection 1946-51, Hyderabad Leaders: Communist Party of India	Cause: The exploitation of peasants by Jagirdars and Deshmukhs (landlords) under the Nizam’s rule, alongside oppressive economic policies like forced labour (Vetti) and high taxes. Key Events: 1940: The formation of Jagir Ryotu Sangham to address peasant issues. 1946: A guerrilla-style armed struggle emerged, supported by the CPI, with attacks on landlords and Razakars (Nizam’s stormtroopers). Outcomes: The movement led to abolition of Vetti, land distribution, and debt settlement.

Peasant Mobilization Across Indian Provinces

Region/ Key Organizations and Leaders	Major Campaigns and Key Events Impact and Successes
Kerala Organisation: Congress Socialist Party, Karshak Sanghams (peasants' organisations)	In 1938, peasants advocated for an amendment to the Malabar Tenancy Act (1929) for better rights and protections for tenant farmers. Impact: Mobilised for tenants' rights in Kerala.
Andhra Pradesh Organisation: India Peasants' Institute (founded by N.G. Ranga, 1933), Summer Schools (by P.C. Joshi, Ajoy Ghosh, R.D. Bhardwaj)	Summer Schools focused on economic and political education for peasants. Electoral defeats of zamindars helped facilitate peasant mobilisation. Impact: India Peasants' Institute worked to spread awareness.
Bihar Organization: Bihar Kisan Sabha Swami Sahajanand Saraswati, Karyanand Sharma, Yadunandan Sharma, Rahul Sankritayan, Panchanan Sharma, Jamun Karjiti	Provincial Kisan Conference (1935) adopted anti-zamindari slogans. Bakasht land issue created a rift with Congress. Impact: Played a significant role in shaping agrarian policies in Bihar. Lost momentum by August 1939, but laid the foundation for future struggles.
Punjab Organisation: Kirti Kisan Party, Punjab Naujawan Bharat Sabha, Akalis, Punjab Kisan Committee	Focused on land revenue issues in Amritsar and Lahore. Protests against water rate hikes in canal colonies like Montgomery and Multan. Impact: Successful strikes led to concessions from authorities. Significant mobilisation in Shekhupura, Jullundur, Amritsar, Hoshiarpur, and Lyallpur.
AIKS Split Leaders: Swami Sahajanand, Indulal Yagnik, N.G. Ranga	The split occurred due to a pro-war stance during World War II. The Kisan Sabha continued despite the split. Impact: Kisan Sabha continued relief work during the 1943 famine.

Working Class Movements

The late 19th century saw the rise of modern **industry** in India, particularly in **coal, cotton, and jute**, forming the backbone of the Indian **working class**. **Labourers, factory workers, and miners** faced harsh **exploitation**, with poor **wages**, long hours, and unsafe conditions, while their struggle was intertwined with the fight for **independence**.

Foundation of Modern Industries (1850-1870)

- **Railway Minute of 1853:** Machinery introduced, leading to the development of railways, coal, cotton, jute, and tea industries.
- **First Cotton Mill:** Bombay, 1854; **First jute mill:** Calcutta, 1855.
- By **1901**, 584,000 factory workers in India.

Early Initiatives to Improve Working Conditions

- **Sasipada Banerjee (1870):** Founded the *Bharat Shramjeevi* and established a workingmen's club to advocate for labour rights.
- **Sorabjee Shapoorji Bengalee (1878):** Proposed a bill in the Bombay Legislative Council to improve working conditions for labourers.
- **Narayan Meghajee Lokhande (1880):** Played a pivotal role in founding the *Deenbandhu* newspaper and establishing the **Bombay Mill and Millhands Association**, which advocated for workers' rights.

[UPSC 2018]

- **Great Indian Peninsular Railways Strike (1899):** Workers of the Great Indian Peninsular Railways went on strike, receiving strong support from nationalist newspapers like Tilak's *Kesari* and *Maharatta*.

Major Factory Acts During British Rule

- **Factory Act of 1881** [UPSC 2017]
 - **Regulation of Working Hours:** Set maximum working hours at 11 hours/day for women and children.
 - **Age Restrictions:** Prohibited the employment of children under 7 years of age and raised the minimum age for children to work to 12 years.
 - **Safety Measures:** Required dangerous machinery to be fenced for protection.
 - **Rest Periods:** Mandated a 13-hour rest period between shifts for women and children.
 - **Inspections and Records:** Factory owners were required to maintain employment and safety records, subject to inspection by government-appointed inspectors.
- **Factory Act of 1891**
 - **Regulation of Working Hours:** Reduced maximum working hours for children to 7 hours a day and raised the minimum working age to 9 and maximum to 14 years.

- **Restrictions on Employment:** Prohibited the employment of children under 7 years of age and limited the workday for women and children to 11 hours.
- **Overtime Wages:** Mandated overtime compensation for work beyond regular hours.
- **Safety Standards:** Included provisions for safety measures in factories to protect workers.
- **Night Work for Children:** Banned the employment of children in factories at night to protect their health.
- **Factory Inspections and Record-Keeping:** Established a system of inspections and required factory owners to maintain detailed records.
- **Factory Acts for the Jute Industry (1909 & 1911)**
 - Specifically focused on regulating working hours and improving safety standards in the jute mills.

Emergence of Political Consciousness

The early 20th century marked the rise of **political consciousness** among India's working class, with key events highlighting their growing awareness and activism.

- **1908 Political Strike in Bombay**
 - Workers organised a **political strike** for nearly a week in response to the conviction and imprisonment of **Lokamanya Tilak**.
 - This strike highlighted the growing political engagement of Indian workers, attracting attention from international figures like **Lenin**, who recognized the Indian proletariat's **class-consciousness** and potential for **political mass struggle**.
- **During the Swadeshi Movement**
 - The **Swadeshi Movement** (nationalist upsurge promoting locally-made goods) saw active **worker participation** in **political and industrial struggles**.
 - **Strikes:** Leaders like **Ashwini Coomar Banerjee**, **Prabhat Kumar Roy Chaudhuri**, **Premtosh Bose**, and **Apurba Kumar Ghosh** organised strikes in industries such as government printing presses, **railways**, and **jute**. These strikes were linked to broader nationalist objectives.
 - **Trade Unions:** Early attempts to form **trade unions** were made, though they had limited initial success. These unions aimed to organise workers for better rights and welfare.
 - **Leader's Role:** **Subramaniya Siva** and **Chidambaram Pillai** led significant strikes in **Tuticorin** and **Tirunelveli**, addressing local grievances. Both were arrested for their activism.
- **Formation of the Chennai Labour Union (1918):** **B.P. Wadia** established the **Chennai Labour Union**, the first Indian **trade union** to operate on modern lines, marking a milestone in labour organisation.

- **Formation of All-India Trade Union Congress (AITUC)**
Establishment (1920): AITUC was founded on **October 31, 1920**, to organise the growing discontent among workers.
 - **Lala Lajpat Rai**, President of the Indian National Congress, became its **first president**, emphasising the connection between **capitalism** and **imperialism**.
 - **Dewan Chaman Lal** served as the **first general secretary**.
- **Influential Leaders:** The movement had strong connections with prominent leaders like **C.R. Das**, **V.V. Giri**, **Sarojini Naidu**, **J.L. Nehru**, and **Subhas Bose**, who presided over AITUC's sessions.

AITUC's Early Orientation

- **Social Democratic Influence:** Initially, AITUC was influenced by the **British Labour Party's social democratic ideals**, with leaders like **N.M. Joshi** advocated for **economic improvements** rather than extensive **political activities**.
- **Gandhian Influence:** Over time, the **Gandhian philosophy** of **non-violence**, **trusteeship**, and **class collaboration** shaped the movement, leading to fewer **strikes** and more **cooperative efforts**. Gandhi helped organise the **Ahmedabad Textile Labour Association (1918)**, securing a **27.5% wage increase** for workers (later raised to **35%**).

Key Developments

- **Gaya Congress Session (1922):** The Congress welcomed the formation of AITUC, forming a committee to support its activities.
- **C.R. Das's Advocacy:** C.R. Das argued that Congress should include the **workers** and **peasants** in the **freedom struggle** to prevent them from becoming alienated from the movement.

Trade Union Act of 1926

- The **Trade Union Act of 1926** legalised trade unions, granting them recognition and regulating their activities. It required at least seven members for registration, provided immunity from civil and criminal liability for legitimate actions, and allowed unions to own property. However, the Act restricted unions from using funds for political purposes, limiting their activities to economic grievances only.

Communist Influence and Legislative Restrictions (Late 1920s)

The rise of **communism** in the late 1920s significantly influenced the **Indian trade union movement**, giving it a more **militant and revolutionary** tone. The **Girni Kamgar Union** led a **six-month strike** at the **Bombay Textile Mills** in 1928, marking a period of intense **industrial unrest** driven by communist ideologies.

- **Communist Leaders:** Key figures such as **Sohan Singh Joshi**, **P.C. Joshi**, **Muzaffar Ahmed**, and **S.A. Dange** played a central role in the **communist-influenced** trade union movement.
- **International Influence:** The **4th Congress of the Communist International** urged the **AITUC** to not just demand fair wages, but to focus on **overthrowing capitalism and imperialism**. AITUC later affiliated with the **Pan-Pacific Secretariat** and the **Third International** in **Moscow**.
- **Moderate Response:** In response to the radical shift, moderates led by **N.M. Joshi** formed the **All India Trade Union Federation (AITUF)** in 1931, after withdrawing from the AITUC.
- **Government Response:** To curb the growing strength of the radicalised trade union movement, the British government implemented several **legislative restrictions**.
- **Trade Disputes Act (TDA), 1929:**
 - **Compulsory Appointment of Courts of Inquiry** and **Consultation Boards** to settle industrial disputes.
 - **Illegal Strikes:** Strikes in **public utility services** (like railways, posts, water, and electricity) were **made illegal** unless individual workers gave a **one-month notice**.
 - **Prohibited Coercive Actions:** The Act forbade coercive or purely political trade union activities, including **sympathetic strikes**. [UPSC 2017]
- **Public Safety Ordinance (1929):** This ordinance, introduced in the **Legislative Assembly in 1928** and enacted in 1929, was aimed at regulating and limiting **labour movements** and **public safety** concerns.
- It provided for a system of tribunals and a ban on strikes. [UPSC 2017]



Trade Unions Under Congress Ministries (1937-1947)

- **Increased Unions:** 296 unions by 1938
- **Kanpur Workers' Strike (1937):** 10,000 workers, 55-day strike
- **Labour Enquiry Committee:** Chaired by Babu Rajendra Prasad

Legislative Reforms: Bombay Industrial Disputes Act (1938), Bombay Shop Assistants Act (1939), C.P. Maternity Act (1939)

Committees: Labour enquiry committees formed by Congress-led provincial governments

Post-1931 and Congress Ministries

- **N.M. Joshi broke away from the AITUC** to set up the **All India Trade Union Federation in 1931**.
- In **1935**, the communists rejoined the AITUC.
- The left front now included communists, Congress socialists, and leftist nationalists like **Jawahar Lal Nehru** and **Subhas Chandra Bose**.
- AITUC supported Congress candidates in the 1937 elections.
- Congress ministries were generally sympathetic to workers' demands, passing favourable labour legislation.

Second World War and Post-Independence

- Initially, **workers opposed the war**, but communist support shifted after Russia's involvement.
- The communists didn't support the Quit India Movement and advocated the policy of industrial peace.
- Workers participated in the post-War national upsurges, and in 1945, the dock workers of Bombay and Calcutta refused to load ships taking supplies to the warring troops in Indonesia. They went on strikes in support of the **Naval Ratings** in 1946.